

FRIVOLITY AT COURT

Henri III, who reigned as King of Poland-Lithuania from 1573–75, and of France from 1574–89, was an elegant, cultured young man who adored clothes and dressing up. He demanded the highest standards of dress from his courtiers, especially the effeminate, frivolous young men in his entourage called *Les Mignons* (Darlings). They plucked their eyebrows, powdered their faces, and adopted feminine accessories such as small dogs and muffs. His mistresses wore the kind of exuberant dress seen in this ball painting. The flat French farthingale, would-be lovers complained, kept men at a distance, as did huge stuffed sleeves. The turned-back fronts of gowns revealed white bosoms above sharply pointed bodices supported by whalebone. Both sexes indulged in luxuries, such as exquisite lace, perfume, and jewellery – Henri was noted for his pearl earrings.

Henri lightened the austere Spanish influence at the French court. Men and women wore such vast starched ruffs that people told courtiers they looked like John the Baptist's head on the platter. From his time as Polish king he brought back fuller breeches called Venetians or Polacks, as well as small Polish caps decorated with gems and aigrettes. Once he galloped through Paris's streets with 30 young men all dressed alike in Italian-inspired pantaloons. Banquets where men dressed as women and vice versa, or spectacular balls where male clothing outshone female, show Henri III's appetite for fun, novelty, pleasure, and flair – the essence of fashion.

“...exceedingly odious, as much by their foolish and haughty demeanour, as by their effeminate and immodest dress...”

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER PIERRE DE L'ESTOILE DESCRIBING
THE KING'S FAVOURITES, 1576

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◀ **EVENING BALL FOR THE WEDDING OF THE DUC DE JOYEUSE, 1581–82**
Henri III is third from the left, wearing black, next to his mother Catherine de' Medici. The rare full-length and back views convey all the vivacity of court fashion during his reign.

